



“It is our **manifest destiny** to overspread the **continent** allotted by Providence for the free development of our yearly multiplying millions.”

JOHN L. O’SULLIVAN, NEW YORK *MORNING NEWS*, DECEMBER 27, 1845

In 1846, Oregon Country was split with the British, again along the 49th parallel, providing a Pacific frontier.

Further expansion came quickly. In 1836, Texas had become independent from Mexico. Its annexation by the US in 1845 led to war with Mexico, bringing California, Nevada, Utah, Arizona, and New Mexico into the nation in 1848. The Gadsden Purchase from Mexico in 1853 provided the land for the South Pacific Railroad to California and so confirmed the southern border. With the purchase of Alaska from Russia in 1867, the US completed its continental growth.

Land of opportunity

As politics and war settled the frontiers, countless intrepid migrants settled the land. Families traveled west from the Mississippi along designated trails.

The numbers were impressive. Three years after the opening of the Oregon Trail through the Rockies in 1841, 5,000 settlers a year were making the challenging journey.

Through the 1862 Homestead Act, the government offered farmers ownership of 160 acres of public land after they had farmed it for five years. Nebraska had been described by an army expedition in 1820, as “wholly unfit for farming,” yet 72,000 people flocked there in four years to build houses of earth, and live off the soil. Land was not the only draw; the discovery of gold in California in 1848

attracted 80,000 prospectors within a year. Others went west to start up new businesses or seek adventure.

The completion of a transcontinental railroad in 1869 (see left), and three more by 1883, further opened up the west. The railroads brought new settlers west and also helped farmers already there, as cattle and grain could be transported easily to cities back in the east.

The massacre of the Sioux ghost dancers at Wounded Knee on December 29, 1890 ended the wars with the American Indians. America had overcome the obstacles to its occupation of the continent.



Alaskan check

In 1867, the year before this check was issued, the US negotiated the purchase of Alaska with the Russian imperial government.



American immigrants

From 1892 to 1954, 12 million people passed through the main immigration center of Ellis Island, New York. Like these children, all were given a health check before being allowed to enter.

AFTER

The United States continued to expand into the 20th century. There were many opportunities to purchase or otherwise take control of land beyond its shores.

FIRST CATCHES

Alaska was bought from Russia in 1867 and **Hawaii, Midway Island, and Wake Island** were annexed in 1898.

FARTHER AFIELD

A war with Spain, precipitated, among other disagreements, by the **sinking of the battleship USS**

Maine off the coast of Cuba in 1898, brought **Puerto Rico, Guam, and the Philippines** under American control. The following year, the US acquired **Samoa** as a naval base and refueling station for ships trading with Asia. In 1917, the **Virgin Islands** were purchased from Denmark to protect Caribbean sea routes.



BATTLESHIP MAINE

RELINQUISHING CONTROL

The US has given up some of its empire. The **Philippines gained independence in 1946**, while three former Japanese island groups in the western Pacific held since 1945 became independent in 1994–96. The **Panama Canal Zone**, American since 1903, was returned to Panama in 1999.

45 The number of states in the Union in 1900